

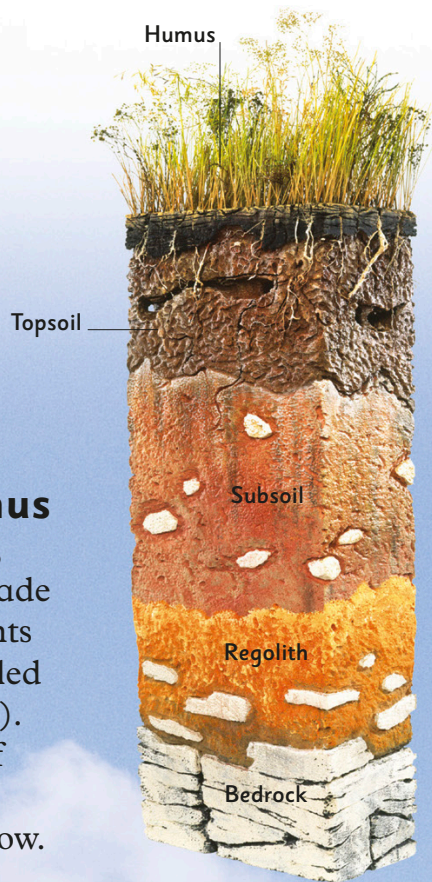
Soil

Soil is the thin layer of loose material on the land. Soil contains minerals, air, water, and decaying organic matter.



Healthy humus

Humus is a dark, rich substance made up of rotting plants and animals (called “organic matter”). It contains lots of nutrients, which plants need to grow.



Layers in soil

Soil builds up in layers over many years. Plant roots grow in the topsoil, which is generally the richest in plant food. The lower layers are rocky. Plant roots do not reach this far down in the soil.

Life underground

Soil is home to thousands of animals, including slugs, ants, beetles, and spiders. Larger animals that spend time underground, such as moles, mix up humus and minerals as they burrow through the soil.

